Sumatran, however, attributes another reason apart from the delay due to the Singur fiasco for the ebbing of interest. He feels that the undue haste in trying to produce the car from the facility in Pantnagar was also a factor. It was only a temporary provision made by yanking a line from the Tata Ace project. Ratan had announced that within a year of pulling out of Singur, he would produce the car. 'It was a rushed promise,' Sumantran says, that left little time for validation of the various car systems.

Ratan was 'distressed' by the steady dwindling of interest. Faced with this development, he addressed Kant, Tata Motors' Group CEO Carl-Peter Forster and Prakash Telang, saying, 'I am astounded by the unbelievably low sales of the Nano' and the 'growing negativity' towards it. He exhorted them to marshal all their 'strength as a company to support the growth in [the] sales of the Nano'. He warned, 'To allow its sales to dwindle and to let this situation drift, will be almost impossible to recover [from]'.

He advised them to pay extra 'managerial and organizational attention on a war footing', stating that it should not be forgotten that the 'Nano created more international visibility for Tata Motors and the Tata Group than anything else in our history'.

Fear of Fire

The Nano suffered from several teething problems, apart from the delay in delivery. There was a disappointing chasm between hope and reality. The expectation from a product launched with so much fanfare, by none other than Ratan, was that it would be flawless, which it was not. To make things worse, as the car was constantly in the media spotlight, reports of problems inevitably spread faster.

After its launch, several Nano cars unexpectedly caught fire. These incidents 'were featured prominently in newspapers and on television' and put a serious question mark on the safety features of the car. Tata Motors stepped in to dispel any doubts about it. Debasis Ray, a spokesperson for the company, declared, 'The car is absolutely safe … As far as we know, more than 85 per cent of customers are happy with the car.' But this aided little in reversing the negative perception, which continued to be one of the reasons for the demand for the car sales to plummet. It was a devastating blow.